

TEACHER LESSON PLAN

The Sound of Harlem

Grades 5–8 · Music

GRADES 5–8 | 45 MINUTES | MUSIC

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

What students will understand

Students will analyze the musical structures of Harlem Renaissance jazz and blues — call-and-response, the 12-bar blues form, improvisation, syncopation, and the role of the rhythm section. They will connect these structures to their African musical roots and understand how jazz was simultaneously a new American art form and a continuation of African musical traditions. Students will respond through structured listening, notation analysis, or original composition.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

- **National Arts MU:Re7.1.5–8** — Demonstrate and explain how responses to music are informed by the structure, the use of the elements of music, and context
- **National Arts MU:Re8.1.5–8** — Support an interpretive claim about the expressive intent of a musical selection with evidence from the elements of music
- **National Arts MU:Cn11.0.5–8** — Demonstrate understanding of relationships between music and the other arts, other disciplines, varied contexts, and daily life

MATERIALS NEEDED

- Audio clips — ideally one each of: 12-bar blues (Bessie Smith), jazz improvisation (Louis Armstrong), big band (Duke Ellington), and stride piano (Fats Waller). All available free via Smithsonian Folkways or YouTube
- Optional: piano or keyboard for demonstrating the 12-bar blues chord progression live
- Differentiated handouts — one per student; pencils for notation work

HOOK · 5 MINUTES

What makes jazz sound like jazz?

Play 30 seconds of straight classical music, then 30 seconds of Louis Armstrong. No introduction.

"Same instruments — woodwinds, brass, strings in the classical piece, brass in the jazz. But they sound completely different. In the next 30 seconds, write down three things that make the jazz sound different from the classical piece. Be specific — not just 'it's more fun.'"

Take responses. Students will typically identify: rhythm (swung/syncopated vs straight), improvisation, call-and-response, the feel of the beat, expression. Affirm and build on these.

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · 12 MINUTES

Jazz structure

Build the structural vocabulary in layers:

Call-and-response: Rooted in West African music and work songs — one voice calls, another answers. In jazz, the trumpet "calls," the rhythm section "responds." Play an example, ask students to identify it.

Syncopation: Emphasis on the off-beat — the "and" between the beats rather than the beat itself. The defining rhythmic feel of jazz and blues. Clap a regular beat, then clap the syncopated version.

12-bar blues form: The harmonic foundation of most early jazz. Play or demonstrate the I–IV–I–V–I progression. Point out: the same 12 bars repeating gives musicians a framework to improvise within.

Improvisation: Creating melody spontaneously within the harmonic structure. Not random — constrained by key, chord changes, and musical conversation with other players.

"Louis Armstrong wasn't just playing notes — he was having a conversation with the other musicians in real time. The structure gave him the rules; improvisation gave him the freedom. That combination — structure and freedom — is the defining idea of jazz."

ACTIVITY: STRUCTURED LISTENING AND RESPONSE · 22 MINUTES

GREEN LEVEL
MORE SUPPORT

Guided listening response to one jazz recording — identify instruments, describe mood, mark where they hear call-and-response, and answer five structured questions. No notation required.

YELLOW LEVEL
GRADE LEVEL

Listen to two contrasting recordings (blues and big band jazz). Complete a comparison framework covering structure, instrumentation, improvisation, and emotional effect. Write a paragraph connecting jazz structure to African musical roots.

RED LEVEL
GO DEEPER

Full structural analysis of one jazz recording: identify 12-bar form, mark syncopation, annotate call-and-response, and evaluate the improvisation. Composition task: write an original 4-bar melodic phrase over a provided blues chord progression, with written rationale for note choices.

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Option 1 — Visit the exhibition: Bring your class to experience the phonograph, the Great Migration Map, the Jazz Lab, and more. Ask your librarian to arrange a visit. **Option 2 — Virtual visit:**
minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

KEY RECORDINGS — TEACHER REFERENCE

- **Blues:** Bessie Smith — "Downhearted Blues" (1923); Ma Rainey — "See See Rider Blues" (1924) — 12-bar form very clear
- **Jazz improvisation:** Louis Armstrong and His Hot Five — "Heebie Jeebies" (1926); "West End Blues" (1928) — Armstrong's trumpet improvisation is definitive
- **Big band:** Duke Ellington — "Take the A Train" (1941); "It Don't Mean a Thing (If It Ain't Got That Swing)" (1932) — the title is a lesson in itself
- **Stride piano:** Fats Waller — "Ain't Misbehavin'" (1929) — demonstrates the stride piano style: left hand alternates bass note and chord, right hand improvises melody

Recordings made before 1926 are now in the US public domain. All of these can be heard free on YouTube, Smithsonian Folkways, or the Internet Archive.

AFRICAN ROOTS — TEACHING NOTES

Jazz did not appear from nowhere. Its structural DNA is deeply African:

- **Call-and-response:** Central to West African vocal and instrumental music, and to the work songs and spirituals of enslaved people in America
- **Polyrhythm:** Multiple simultaneous rhythmic patterns — the drum kit in jazz is essentially a polyrhythmic instrument
- **Improvisation:** The griot tradition in West African music involves improvised storytelling in song — direct ancestor of blues vocal improvisation
- **Blue notes:** The flattened 3rd, 5th, and 7th scale degrees that give blues its distinctive sound — not part of the European harmonic system; rooted in African tonal traditions

CROSS-CURRICULAR CONNECTIONS

- **Science:** Physics of sound — frequency, resonance, the phonograph; how the electric microphone (1925) changed what could be recorded
- **Social Studies:** The Great Migration explains why so many musicians ended up in Harlem simultaneously — critical mass of talent created jazz as a distinct genre
- **ELA:** Langston Hughes wrote about jazz as the sound of the people; his poetry is directly influenced by blues and jazz rhythm and structure
- **Art:** Aaron Douglas's *Song of the Towers* is a visual representation of jazz — the concentric circles are often read as sound waves

ASSESSMENT IDEAS

- **Listening journal:** Students listen to three recordings at home and write one paragraph each describing structure, mood, and one musical choice they found interesting
- **Composition:** Compose and perform a 4-bar melody over the 12-bar blues progression — can be done with voice, any instrument, or body percussion
- **Critical essay:** "Jazz is both African and American — explain how its structure reflects both traditions"

Paintings to project (in copyright, so not printed; each title links to the museum's page): Aspects of Negro Life: Song of the Towers (1934)